

Car Mechanic Dialogue Corpus

CLIENT: My car loses power when I floor the accelerator.

MECHANIC: This usually happens when the fuel filter is partially clogged or when the fuel pump is not maintaining the correct pressure. It is also worth testing the pressure regulator. A line measurement will show what is failing.

CLIENT: There is a strong smell of petrol inside the cabin.

MECHANIC: The smell points to a leak in the fuel circuit, often in the return hose or the evaporation canister. Do not ignore it — there is a fire risk. We need to lift the car, inspect the lines, and replace anything that has dried out.

CLIENT: The car shakes when stopped at a traffic light.

MECHANIC: Vibration at idle points to an ignition fault. It could be worn spark plugs, cables with electrical leakage, or a weak coil. It is also worth testing the throttle body and the idle speed sensor.

CLIENT: The steering wheel is pulling strongly to the right.

MECHANIC: This symptom usually comes from wheel alignment out of spec or uneven tyre pressure. If it persists after calibration, there may be play in the control arm or bushings.

CLIENT: When I turn, I hear a repetitive clicking from the wheel.

MECHANIC: This indicates a worn CV joint. In turns, it operates at a greater angle and wear shows up as clicking. If the boot is torn, the grease is already compromised.

CLIENT: The steering is very heavy.

MECHANIC: Heavy steering generally involves the hydraulic pump, a loose belt, low fluid levels, or a problem in the electric steering module, depending on the vehicle's system.

CLIENT: The car is slow to start in the morning.

MECHANIC: This is typical of weak spark plugs, an overly rich mixture, an engine temperature sensor sending incorrect data, or leaking injectors. Testing line pressure and analysing start time helps identify the cause.

CLIENT: The headlight flickers when I am driving slowly.

MECHANIC: Fluctuating brightness points to an alternator with a failing voltage regulator. Before the battery drains, we need to measure the output under load.

CLIENT: There is a metallic noise when I go over bumps.

MECHANIC: This sound often comes from worn drop links, suspension bushings, or a worn shock absorber mount. The assembly needs a visual inspection to confirm.

CLIENT: The engine dies when I lift off the accelerator.

MECHANIC: Unstable idle is a sign of a dirty throttle body, a faulty idle actuator, or a false air intake at the manifold. A cleaning may fix it, but we could also have a MAP sensor problem.

CLIENT: The battery warning light came on.

MECHANIC: The light means the charging system is not working. Either the alternator is weak or the belt is slipping. If ignored, the car will cut out when the battery runs flat.

CLIENT: I can smell something sweet coming from the engine.

MECHANIC: A sweet smell is usually coolant leaking. It could come from the flange, radiator, hose, or even the heater core. We need to check the level and pressurise the system.

CLIENT: The automatic gearbox jerks when changing gear.

MECHANIC: Jerks come from ATF fluid at the wrong level, dirty mechatronic valves, or internal clutch wear. Analysing the fluid reveals a lot.

CLIENT: The car is using too much fuel.

MECHANIC: High consumption appears with a slow O2 sensor, dirty MAF, blocked air filter, or irregular combustion. A scanner will show the mixture adjustments.

CLIENT: There is a whistling noise when I accelerate.

MECHANIC: This is typical of a leak at the intake manifold or turbo pipework, if present. It could also be a worn auxiliary belt.

CLIENT: My car vibrates strongly above 80 km/h.

MECHANIC: Vibration at higher speed is usually wheel balancing. If it is in the steering wheel, it is the front; if it is in the seat, it is the rear. Also check for deformed tyres.

CLIENT: The clutch is engaging very high, almost at the top of the pedal.

MECHANIC: This shows wear in the clutch assembly. The pressure plate and disc are at their limit. Replacing the full kit is recommended.

CLIENT: Water is coming in through the floor when it rains.

MECHANIC: Almost always a blocked drain, dried door seal, or water getting in through the firewall. We pour water over the car to trace the flow.

CLIENT: The air conditioning turns on but does not cool.

MECHANIC: This indicates low refrigerant, a faulty compressor, a stuck expansion valve, or a blocked condenser. The first step is to measure the pressure.

CLIENT: The car only misfires on ethanol.

MECHANIC: It could be the lambda sensor taking too long to correct, injectors with uneven flow, or the fuel module not adjusting the mixture properly. Separate fuel tests help identify the cause.

CLIENT: My car will not rev above 3,000 rpm.

MECHANIC: This looks like limp mode. It could be the crank sensor, cam sensor, MAF, turbo pressure, or a mixture outside the safe range.

CLIENT: There is foam coming from the coolant reservoir.

MECHANIC: This usually points to a blown head gasket, allowing combustion gases into the cooling system. A CO2 test on the reservoir confirms it.

CLIENT: I hear a loud noise on startup, as if something is scraping.

MECHANIC: Symptom of a starter motor with a worn bendix or a flywheel with damaged teeth.

CLIENT: The steering wheel vibrates every time I brake.

MECHANIC: Steering wheel vibration during braking means warped discs. Skimming or replacement is the fix.

CLIENT: The manual gear change is stiff.

MECHANIC: It could be the clutch cable, the selector cable sticking, or lack of lubrication in the gear linkage. If hydraulic, it could be a failing slave cylinder.

CLIENT: The car is making a toc-toc sound at the front.

MECHANIC: Often it is ball joints, control arm bushings, or a bearing with play. Lifting the car and testing with a lever confirms the component.

CLIENT: The car cannot hold speed on a hill.

MECHANIC: Likely loss of compression, a weak pump, a lean mixture, or a partially blocked catalytic converter. A compression test tells a good part of the story.

CLIENT: When I turn the steering wheel all the way, I hear a creaking.

MECHANIC: Noise at full lock indicates a dry shock absorber bump stop or a worn strut bearing.

CLIENT: The car is burning oil.

MECHANIC: Excessive oil consumption signals worn piston rings, dried valve stem seals, or an external leak that evaporates on the hot engine.

CLIENT: I hear a click when braking gently.

MECHANIC: Often this comes from a caliper with seized pins or loose brake pads. A service call fixes it.

CLIENT: There is a repetitive clicking coming from the dashboard.

MECHANIC: Dashboard clicks usually come from the indicator relay or the climate control system when a flap cannot find the right position.

CLIENT: When I turn off the car, it keeps shaking for a few seconds.

MECHANIC: This can indicate dieseling, where the engine tries to keep running due to internal carbon build-up. Cleaning and mixture adjustment are needed.

CLIENT: My windscreen wipers are very slow.

MECHANIC: Slow wipers usually mean a worn wiper motor, insufficient lubrication on the arms, or increased electrical resistance at the terminals.

CLIENT: My car makes a squealing noise from the belt when I start it in the morning.

MECHANIC: Cold squealing indicates a dried-out auxiliary belt or a weak tensioner. When the engine warms up, the material expands and the noise fades. Replace the belt and check the tensioner bearing.

CLIENT: The engine is oscillating between 800 and 1,500 rpm on its own.

MECHANIC: RPM oscillation points to a false air intake, an irregular throttle body, or a MAF/MAP sensor sending unstable readings. A live scanner shows the culprit.

CLIENT: After heavy rain, the car will not start.

MECHANIC: Excess moisture often causes a short in the spark plug leads, coil failure, or oxidation in the distributor on older models. Drying the connections and testing the spark usually fixes it.

CLIENT: The brake pedal is getting lower every day.

MECHANIC: This suggests a leak in the master cylinder or air in the hydraulic line. It is important to bleed the system and check for leaks at the wheel cylinders.

CLIENT: There is a burning smell coming from the wheels after driving.

MECHANIC: A burning smell can be a seized brake. The caliper may be sticking or the internal flexible hose may have collapsed, keeping pressure on the system.

CLIENT: The car stalls when I engage reverse.

MECHANIC: This could be the idle sensor out of adjustment or a sudden electrical load drop when the gearbox moves into position. Also worth testing the stepper motor and TPS sensor.

CLIENT: I hear a deep rumble when I accelerate above 60 km/h.

MECHANIC: A deep rumble generally points to a worn wheel bearing. The faster you go, the louder it gets.

CLIENT: The ABS warning light came on.

MECHANIC: ABS lights up when one of the wheel sensors loses its reading. It could be a dirty sensor, a broken wire, or a corroded tone ring.

CLIENT: The automatic gearbox is slipping.

MECHANIC: Slipping indicates ATF fluid below the correct level or internal wear of the bands and clutches. The fluid may smell burnt, revealing overheating.

CLIENT: When I accelerate gently, the car judders slightly.

MECHANIC: Light juddering under low load points to a failing coil, a spark plug with the wrong gap, or low-octane fuel.

CLIENT: The car shudders when I turn on the air conditioning.

MECHANIC: Shuddering when the AC engages indicates excessive load on the compressor, a weak engine mount, or an idle speed not correctly calibrated for automatic compensation.

CLIENT: The car door does not close properly.

MECHANIC: It could be a misaligned striker, a dirty latch, or a seal that has lost its elasticity. Fine adjustment of the hinge fixes most cases.

CLIENT: The steering makes a humming noise when manoeuvring.

MECHANIC: Humming is typical of a hydraulic pump with low fluid or starting to wear. Topping up the fluid and testing the pressure is the way forward.

CLIENT: When I accelerate hard, black smoke comes from the exhaust.

MECHANIC: Black smoke indicates a rich mixture, caused by a dirty MAF, excessive fuel pressure, a slow O2 sensor, or dripping injectors.

CLIENT: The car is backfiring from the exhaust.

MECHANIC: Backfire is normally caused by a lean mixture, advanced ignition timing, or a leak at the exhaust manifold.

CLIENT: My speedometer has stopped working.

MECHANIC: If the speedometer is electronic, the problem is the speed sensor. If mechanical, it is a broken speedometer cable.

CLIENT: After replacing the battery, several systems stopped working.

MECHANIC: There may have been a loss of module configuration. Some cars need a relearn procedure for the throttle body, windows, radio, and even the immobiliser.

CLIENT: There is water in the boot.

MECHANIC: This usually comes from the boot lid seal, a blocked drain, or water getting in around the rear light cluster.

CLIENT: The engine is burning too much fuel when I use the air conditioning.

MECHANIC: The AC adds extra load to the engine. If consumption is excessive, the compressor is likely under strain, the mixture is rich, or the ECU is compensating for a faulty sensor.

CLIENT: My car vibrates above 120 km/h.

MECHANIC: Beyond balancing, high speed exposes play in the suspension, deformed tyres, or even misaligned driveshafts.

CLIENT: The clutch makes a whistling noise when I press the pedal.

MECHANIC: This noise comes from the release bearing. When the pedal is pressed, it engages and the wear becomes audible.

CLIENT: The car is slow to change gear automatically.

MECHANIC: It could be old ATF fluid, the gearbox module learning incorrect patterns, or slow-responding internal solenoids.

CLIENT: The glove box will not close.

MECHANIC: Almost always a misaligned latch or a broken internal catch. Adjustment or replacement is the fix.

CLIENT: When I accelerate gently, I hear a sandy noise.

MECHANIC: That gritty sound could be the alternator bearing, tensioner, or a wheel bearing starting to fail.

CLIENT: My car shakes when carrying a full load of passengers.

MECHANIC: This exposes already weak shock absorbers, suffering mounts, or tired springs. Extra weight reveals existing faults.

CLIENT: The car does not respond to the accelerator sometimes.

MECHANIC: The fault could be the TPS sensor, the electronic pedal, a dirty throttle body, or an intermittent module failure.

CLIENT: Blue smoke comes out when I accelerate hard.

MECHANIC: Blue smoke means oil is burning. Under hard acceleration, it comes from worn piston rings or scored cylinder walls.

CLIENT: The rear light turns on and off by itself.

MECHANIC: This can be a bad connection at the socket, oxidation, or a poor earth.

CLIENT: The car has a constant hum from the rear.

MECHANIC: A continuous rumble is a rear wheel bearing asking to be replaced.

CLIENT: The coolant level keeps dropping but I see no leak.

MECHANIC: If it is not dripping on the ground, it could be evaporating through a micro-crack, being burnt in the combustion chamber due to a failed head gasket, or leaking through the heater core.

CLIENT: The car jerks when it automatically downshifts.

MECHANIC: Harsh downshifts happen with a sticking solenoid, old fluid, or a module working with incorrect data.

CLIENT: The suspension bottoms out on every bump.

MECHANIC: Hard knocks are typical of a blown shock absorber, a collapsed mount, or a drop link with play.

CLIENT: There is a strong smell of burning oil when I stop the car.

MECHANIC: There may be a leak dripping onto the exhaust. The cam cover gasket, valve cover, or sump could be the culprits.

CLIENT: The traction control warning light came on.

MECHANIC: This indicates a fault in a wheel sensor, the steering angle sensor, the stability module, or a sharp speed difference between wheels.

CLIENT: The car misfires only at high speed.

MECHANIC: High-speed misfires can come from a weak fuel pump, a blocked filter, or a restriction in the catalytic converter.

CLIENT: When I go over a speed bump, I hear a squeak.

MECHANIC: A rubber squeak is almost always a dried-out bushing or a shock absorber bump stop.

CLIENT: The car lost power after I replaced the exhaust.

MECHANIC: There may be a restriction in the new silencer, a leak at the manifold, or an O2 sensor that has not yet adapted to the new readings.

CLIENT: When I press the clutch, I hear a loud creaking.

MECHANIC: Creaking when pressing the pedal indicates a dry clutch cable or a clutch fork that needs lubrication. If the noise comes from the gearbox, it may be a worn pilot bearing.

CLIENT: The car is dripping a red liquid on the ground.

MECHANIC: Red fluid is almost always automatic transmission fluid (ATF). The source could be the transmission sump gasket, a seal, or the oil cooler hose.

CLIENT: After washing the engine, the car will not start.

MECHANIC: This is common when water gets into electrical connectors, sensors, or the coil. Drying and cleaning with contact spray usually fixes it.

CLIENT: The oil pressure warning light flickered while I was driving.

MECHANIC: Intermittent oil pressure indicates a dirty oil pickup, a worn oil pump, or a low level. This is critical — driving like this can cause serious engine damage.

CLIENT: The car creaks when I go over a dip slowly.

MECHANIC: Creaks during suspension travel can come from broken springs, control arm bushings, or a drop link with play.

CLIENT: The electric window will not go all the way up.

MECHANIC: It could be a dirty rail, a tired motor, or a missing relearn on the door module. Silicone lubricant helps.

CLIENT: I can smell rotten eggs from the exhaust.

MECHANIC: This smell indicates a saturated catalytic converter or an extremely rich mixture overloading the emissions system.

CLIENT: My car stalls when I turn on many electrical items.

MECHANIC: This points to a weak alternator, a faulty regulator, or a battery at the end of its life. A load test confirms it.

CLIENT: The manual gear lever is vibrating in my hand.

MECHANIC: Vibration in the lever shows worn engine and gearbox mounts or a misaligned gear linkage.

CLIENT: The heater is no longer working.

MECHANIC: The heater depends on the heater core. If it is not heating, the core may be blocked, the thermostat valve stuck, or the engine not reaching operating temperature.

CLIENT: The car is backfiring through the air filter.

MECHANIC: Backfire at the intake indicates a fault on the intake side, normally caused by a misadjusted intake valve, a lean mixture, or incorrect ignition timing.

CLIENT: My tyres are wearing on the inside.

MECHANIC: Inner wear reveals negative camber out of spec or control arms with play. A full alignment is needed.

CLIENT: The brake pedal shudders when I brake hard.

MECHANIC: Shuddering is ABS activating, but if it is excessive it could indicate a warped disc or an ABS sensor misreading.

CLIENT: The car will not downshift when I floor it to overtake.

MECHANIC: Kickdown problem. The sensor may be inoperative, the cable out of adjustment, or the gearbox module not responding correctly.

CLIENT: I hear a squealing inside the car coming from the dashboard.

MECHANIC: Often it is the interior fan with dust on the blades or a worn ventilation motor bearing.

CLIENT: The starter is slow when the engine is hot.

MECHANIC: A slow hot start indicates an overheating starter motor, a poor earth connection, or a battery with high internal resistance.

CLIENT: When I drive on wet roads, the car slides easily.

MECHANIC: This points to worn tyres, shallow tread, or hardened rubber compound. Checking alignment and tyre pressure also helps.

CLIENT: My car makes a knocking noise when I turn off the engine.

MECHANIC: It could be collapsed mounts, a loose exhaust, or even the engine rocking due to internal imbalance.

CLIENT: The gears will not go in at all when the car is cold.

MECHANIC: Classic symptom of gearbox oil that is too thick, worn synchromesh, or a clutch that is not fully disengaging.

CLIENT: When I go over rough ground, I hear a toc-toc at the rear.

MECHANIC: Usually the anti-roll bar, rear drop link, or a shock absorber with play at the top mount.

CLIENT: The car is pulling to one side even after alignment.

MECHANIC: There may be a misaligned subframe, a bent arm, or internal play in the steering rack.

CLIENT: My horn only works sometimes.

MECHANIC: Likely a fault in the clock spring contact, a poor earth, or a tired relay.

CLIENT: The car misfires when the tank is below a quarter full.

MECHANIC: Sign of a dirty fuel pickup, a weak pump, or accumulated dirt reaching the injectors.

CLIENT: The airbag warning light came on.

MECHANIC: Usually a disconnected seat connector, a faulty impact sensor, or the module logging an internal error.

CLIENT: I hear a hum that increases with speed, without accelerating.

MECHANIC: This points to a wheel bearing. The noise is independent of acceleration and follows only wheel rotation.

CLIENT: My brakes are squealing even with new pads.

MECHANIC: It could be the wrong pad material, missing anti-squeal paste, or a disc with an uneven surface.

CLIENT: The fuel cap is hard to open.

MECHANIC: Likely the actuator latch sticking or a worn release cable.

CLIENT: The car makes a metal scraping noise on startup.

MECHANIC: This indicates a failing starter motor bendix that is not correctly engaging the flywheel ring gear.

CLIENT: My electric power steering fails sometimes and a warning light comes on.

MECHANIC: Torque sensor fault, the module overheating, or an intermittent failure in the column's electric motor.

CLIENT: When I turn left, the car makes a deep rumble.

MECHANIC: If the noise only appears when turning, it is the bearing on the opposite side — most likely the right.

CLIENT: The car overheats on long uphill sections.

MECHANIC: This can indicate a weak fan, a radiator with reduced flow, or a worn water pump.

CLIENT: My CVT gearbox is whining.

MECHANIC: Whining in a CVT shows the steel belt under excessive tension or fluid out of specification. The fluid needs changing and wear needs to be assessed.

CLIENT: The fuel gauge dropped too quickly.

MECHANIC: The level sensor may be stuck, the float punctured, or the instrument cluster module failing.

CLIENT: I hear a ticking noise from the engine when it is cold.

MECHANIC: Usually a hydraulic tappet that has drained. After a few minutes the oil pressurises and the noise disappears.

CLIENT: The car shudders when releasing the clutch from a standstill.

MECHANIC: Shuddering on take-off is a contaminated clutch disc, an uneven pressure plate, or worn mounts.

CLIENT: There is a smell of burning plastic coming from inside the cabin.

MECHANIC: It could be the blower motor resistor overheating or a wiring harness with a bad contact behind the dashboard.